

Signaling on the battlefield

In 1856, Lieutenant Albert J. Myer had created a system of “wigwag” signaling, which was used before the introduction of the telegraph. Standing on a platform, the signaler waved a single flag (or a lantern at night) back and forth to represent different letters of the alphabet. By 1861, the system had been accepted by the U.S. Army and Myers had been made founding officer of the U.S. Signal Corps. On both sides, officers were assigned at various levels of army command to facilitate communication primarily on the battlefield and on the march, where the telegraph was less useful. In the Confederacy, signal corpsmen also served as guides for blockade runners at night, lighting lanterns along entrances to the major ports, and as military intelligence gatherers, especially in Virginia.



Night lantern

A member of the Signal Corps uses a kerosene lantern on a long handle for wigwag signaling at night, moving the lantern back and forth to send messages. Beside him a man watches for the replies.

Changing the course of battle

Signal corpsmen proved decisive in the outcome of some key battles. At the First Battle of Bull Run, a Confederate wigwag team